

IRE OF THE MINORITIES

Christian and Muslim groups say the proposed reforms in education are aimed at hurting religious sentiments

■ By M.G. Radhakrishnan

Communists never miss an opportunity to pride themselves as saviours of minorities. But, at least in states where they are in power, the minorities refuse to see them as saviours and consider them their arch enemies. If Nandigram and Taslima Nasrin brought Muslims in West Bengal to the streets against the Left Front Government, in Kerala, most Christian and Muslim organisations are now up in arms against the Left Democratic Front (LDF) Government's reforms in minority-dominated education sector. The Opposition, United Democratic Front, has pledged its support to their agitation.

The latest to bring minority ire against the Left are the recommendations—expected to be made—by an expert committee formed by the state government to amend the 50-year-old Kerala Educational Rules. Both Christian churches and Muslim religious organisations are already agitated even after the Government's repeated assurance that none of the feared recommendations would be implemented and that they have not yet been finalised by the expert committee. "We are neither contemplating any changes in school timings, which would clash with madrasa classes nor is there a proposal to allow boys and girls sit together. This is a calumny spread by vested interests against the Government," says Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan. Alarmed by the anger of the minorities, Education Minister M.A. Baby met the powerful Sunni cleric Kanthapuram A.P. Abubaker Maulavi and assured him that there was nothing to fear.

But this has cut no ice with the minority groups. The state madrasa co-ordination committee closed down about 20,000 madrasas on December 13 in protest. A state-level agitation plan has already been announced by various Muslim religious organisations with the full backing of the Muslim League. They have demanded that the activities of the Kerala Sasthra Sahithya Parishad, a prominent pro-Left popular science movement and winner of the Right Livelihood Award be banned in schools. "They are behind the moves to impose the atheist agenda," stated Samasta Kerala Jamiyyathul Ulema. The organisation has also charged that there was a proposal to allow boys and girls in high schools to sit side-by-side in classrooms in the name of gender justice. "We will not allow this," says Ulema President Kalampady Muhammed Musaliar. An anti-Government campaign centred in mosques will be launched by the organisation. "We will not allow Kerala to turn into a Bengal. Religious sentiments cannot be trampled upon," says Muslim League leader Panakkad Shihab Thangal. Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee President Ramesh Chennithala echoes the sentiment.

The Christian groups, especially the Catholic church, which had been at war with the Government in its earlier moves to control self-financing professional colleges, have taken a more belligerent posture. Pastoral letters have been read out in all the churches warning against any truck with atheists. The Catholic church has also launched an agitation against the Government in assembly constituencies. "Yes, it is a political move to garner all Christian



WRATH: Madrasa committee protest (top); Christian leaders meet



"We have no plans to take over minority-run institutions."

V.S. ACHUTHANANDAN, CHIEF MINISTER